

TOPIC:

EXISTING CAPACITY IN IRAN – AFRICA CULTURAL COOPERATION

PROTOCOL

INTRODUCTION

It is not out of place to say strong cultural cooperation ties have been built century ago between Africa and Iran and it's dynamism has continued to grow in the 21st century. These ties and cooperation included but not limited to Culture, Religion, Tradition and Spiritualism. This paper intends to highlight and examine the capacity of these cultural cooperation ties as it is in Iran and Africa with particular reference to Nigeria.

PAPER PRESENTATION

Iran – Africa relationship have continued to grow further since the new millennium. The nature of the relationship was broadened and was shifting from specific projects to economic; commercial and investment cooperation.

These two countries have century of friendship with the giant of African Nigeria. They struggled for Freedom, Equity and Justice for their people and beyond. The two have also shared rich culture and people relations for long. The Iranian foreign and economic policies always gives special attention for the African continent and put it at the centre. After its revolution, the Republic of Iran has changed its foreign policy orientation and its economic ties towards developing countries based on the principles of non-interference and win-win cooperation. On the aftermath of the revolution, Iran cultivated strong relationships with many African countries and established joint Economic Commissions with most of them.

Energy generation capacity of Iranian Thermal power plants reached 173 terawatt hours in 2007. Accounting for 17.9 percent of energy production in the middle East and African Region.

A one day Iranian – Africa dialogue organized sometimes ago in Pretoria South African capital stresses the need for expansion of ties between Iran and Africa.

The cultural dialogue had in attendance South Africa, Nigeria and other African countries.

In the conference Mohsen Movehidi Ghomi, the Iranian Ambassador to South Africa said Iran and Africa have long standing relationships which date back to 4,000 years BC. In fact he even mentioned that the Iranian used to live in several parts of Africa such as Egypt, Algeria, Tunisia and East of continent. He also went ahead to state that Iranian did not only settled but integrated well in African societies through trade relations and marriages and had great influence over the continent culture.

The Iran after the revolution supported the oppressed and severed its relations with the South African apartheid regime while supported the liberation movement there and after the collapse of the Apartheid regime in the 1990s, it reestablished ties with the country.

Nigeria would gain particular importance in Iran with West Africa, Nigeria has its high population density, and more than half of them are Muslim, also has strategic and economic importance as one of the most important oil-producing countries in Africa.

Both Nigeria and Iran have a lot to share in the areas of Science and Technology, Agriculture, Culture and Tourism as well as the extractive industry.

Iranian opening to Africa is backing to the era of former President Hashemi Rafsanjani, who had paid much attention for this continent and that was after his visit to Sudan in 1991 after overthrowing the government of Sadiq Al-Mahid by Omar Al-Bashir.

Rafsanjani's visit to Sudan represented considerable support for al-imposed by the international community.

This visit marked a new era in the Iranian relations with Africa also a starting point to expand its concern in this continent, as this expansion extended to include other African countries such as South Africa, Kenya,

Tanzania, Zimbabwe, Uganda, Nigeria, Niger, Cameroon, Senegal, Comoros, Somalia, Djibouti, and Ghana.

Among succession of the Iranian presidency, Africa was on the state agenda. After Rafsanjani's visit to Sudan, which followed by another one in 1996, Mohammed Khatami's visits to some African countries gave a new impetus of new relations with these countries through establishing frameworks and joint committees which have been handled the task of following up agreements between Iran and these countries. Then Ahmadinejad, who had made several visits to Africa that marked mostly by an ideological character. After that, President Hassan Rouhani dispatched his foreign minister, Mohammad Javad Zarif in several visits to East Africa in the winter of 2014, and another visit to North African countries in the summer of 2015, in addition to his recent trip to West Africa in July 2016. Perhaps those successive visits reflect the desire of the Iranian regime to move forward in consolidating relations with the largest number of African countries.

These consecutive visits of Iranian officials appeared in joint committees between these countries and Iran which resulted in bilateral treaties and agreements in dam construction, automotive industry, energy, as well as financial and banking affairs. Furthermore, cultural and educational cooperation. Iran also provided attractive economic promises through which many African nations forced to make concessions in strategic and security files.

The Iranian regime motives varied behind the incursion in Africa from one country to another, economically, politically and religious.

Moreover, to achieve the objectives of the Iranian regime in the African continent, it had to search for strategic areas from which begins and uses primary pathway to reach the desired targets. The focus was on Sudan and Nigeria clearly, and that because of their extraordinary features compared to the countries of the region.

This Iranian vast openness and focus on Sudan and Nigeria has an adverse impact on social and cultural fabric of these countries, as reflected

negatively on the relationship between Sudan and Arab surroundings, so the main question that will come to everyone's mind is:

What are the main reasons and motives of the Iranian presence in Sudan and Nigeria?

Conclusion

Available records shows that trade between the two countries is still below \$500 million yearly.

Ladies and Gentlemen I wish to call on Nigeria and Iran to use their membership of various International Organizations such as the United National (UN), Organization of the Petroleum Exporting, Countries, (OPEC), Origination of Islamic Cooperation, (OIC) and others to improve economic and trade relations for the benefit of the people.

We are both aware that there are lots of capacities and capabilities that should be taken into serious consideration. Africa has always been the major strategic partner of Iran and of course friend of Nigeria, we therefore look forward to consolidating the good relationship that always exist between the two countries.

Thank you all.